CASTE STILL COUNTS

Ever since Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar announced the results of the caste survey in his state on Gandhi Jayanti, the idea of a nationwide caste census has caught the imagination of the Congress leadership, Rahul in particular. Putting its weight behind the demand now, the Congress wants the 50 per cent cap on reservations removed and more allotted to OBCs, Scheduled Castes and Tribes. In all three states, it has announced that if voted to power, a caste census will be government priority.

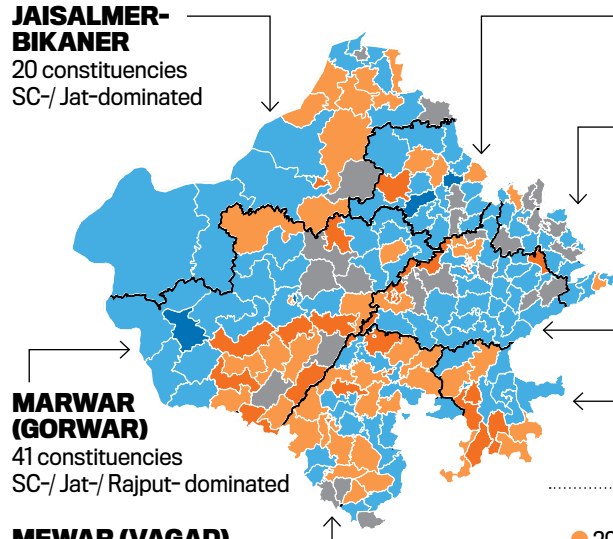
The BJP, meanwhile, has been non-committal on the issue, loath to open a pandora's box on the eve of elections and fearing a backlash from its upper caste voters. It's adopting a dual approach instead. So, the Union government is ruling out a national caste census on the grounds that it is logistically unfeasible, and PM Modi is dismissing the Opposition's demand as an attempt to divide the country and society. On the other hand, state units and leaders, including the party's national OBC Morcha, are batting for caste counts in states. The party is also aggressively promoting its model of "*samagra samajik nyay*" (holistic social justice) as a contrast to the Opposition's "bare representative politics". Projecting it as a step beyond reservations, "*samagra samajik nyay*" promises empowerment on the ground and fulfilment of the economic aspirations of the poor. The recent Rs 13,000-crore PM Vishwakarma Kaushal Samman Yojana is being cited as a representative example, as part of which 18 marginalised artisan backward communities are offered financial assistance along with training and guidance.

However, sensing the BJP's discomfort on the subject, the Congress is moving in for the kill, ratcheting up the demand for a caste count, hoping to dent the BJP's OBC support base. The Congress is constantly reminding voters that three of its four CMs—Ashok Gehlot in Rajasthan, Bhupesh Baghel in Chhattisgarh, and Siddaramaiah in Karnataka—are OBCs.

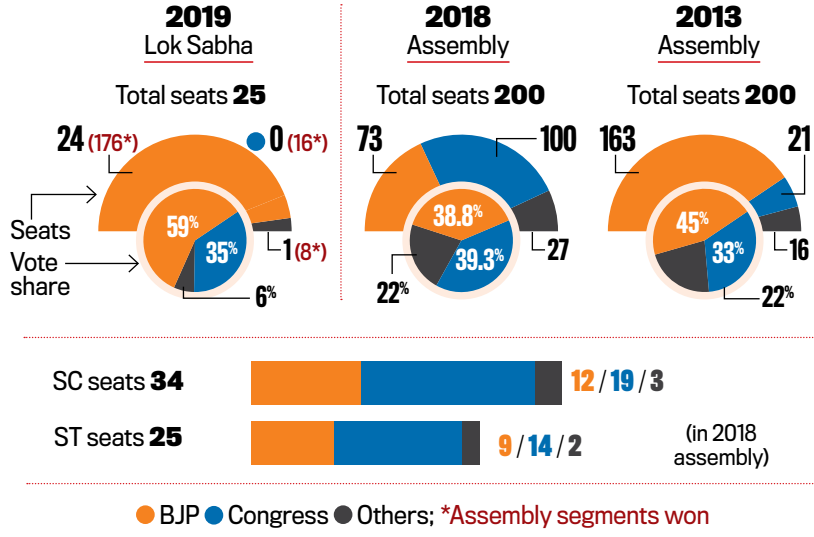
RAJASTHAN

THE BATTLEGROUND

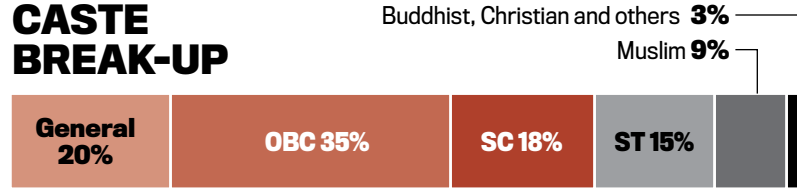
IN RAJASTHAN, THE BJP HAS RECORDED THREE SUCCESSIVE WINS IN 28 ASSEMBLY SEGMENTS, INCLUDING 3 SC SEATS. THERE ARE 5 SEATS THAT THE CONGRESS HAS NOT LOST IN THE PAST 3 POLLS



HOW THE TWO PARTIES PERFORMED



CASTE BREAK-UP



Source: Election Commission of India; Caste and region break-up with inputs from Axis My India and India Today bureau